



THE TRUTH IS THAT MEN ARE TIRED OF LIBERTY

THE REICHSTAG FIRE (1933)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Rise of fascism

BEFORE

1918 World War I leaves Europe politically and economically unstable.

1920 The National Socialist (or Nazi) Party is founded in Germany, with racism a central tenet.

1922 Benito Mussolini is made Italian premier by King Victor Emmanuel III.

AFTER

1935 Mussolini invades Abyssinia (Ethiopia) as part of his ambitious foreign policy.

1936–1939 The Spanish Civil War is fought.

1938 Adolf Hitler invades Austria. The Munich Pact grants Hitler control of the Sudetenland.

1939 Hitler orders the invasion of Poland, which triggers World War II.

When fire broke out at the Reichstag, the German parliament building, just after 9pm on February 27, 1933, Chancellor Adolf Hitler claimed it was a communist plot to bring down the government—a cynical ploy that gave Hitler an excuse to decimate his communist rivals.

Slowing European economies make everyday life harder.

German resentment festers over the terms of the **Treaty of Versailles**.

Extremist fascist and communist ideologies seem to offer easy solutions to **national problems**.

The Reichstag Fire is blamed on the communists and is used as a pretext to curb civil liberties and jail dissenters.

The **disintegration of formal structures** of government clears the way for **Adolf Hitler** to become dictator.

The timing was perfect: elections were due to take place in March 1933. While Hitler's National Socialist, or "Nazi," Party was the largest party in parliament, he lacked a working majority because the two next-largest parties (the Social Democrats and Communists) were both on the left, and he feared his party would not fare well in the elections. Hitler rushed to blame the fire on a lone Dutch communist, which